

FLORIDA EVERGLADES

The largest wetland wilderness in the US

The Everglades is a complex of low-lying, densely vegetated wetlands incorporating a mosaic of habitats. The region lacks the scenic grandeur of some other US national parks, but an area in the south was granted protected status in 1934 on account of its unique ecology and biodiversity. The diverse array of interlinking habitats are defined by the depth, quality, and salinity of the water, and the frequency and duration of flooding.

River of grass

The park's coastal ecosystems include estuaries, tidal mangrove swamps, and coastal prairies dominated by salt- and drought-tolerant succulent plants. These give way inland to prairies and sparsely canopied forests of fast-growing slash pine, which are periodically razed by fire. The prairies are interspersed with lower-lying areas almost permanently inundated with

water flowing slowly south from Lake Okeechobee toward Florida Bay. These wet sawgrass prairies—known locally as the river of grass—include areas of sluggish open water, or sloughs, and cypress swamps. Small patches of slightly higher ground support hammocks of hardwood forest with trees including tropical mahogany and temperate oak, usually dripping with ferns and airplants (epiphytes).

More than 300 species of fish live in the Everglades, along with the largest breeding populations of tropical waders in North America. The region is also home to 50 species of reptile, including the American alligator and the threatened American crocodile.



SHARK NURSERY
Baby bull sharks are vulnerable to predation, so females enter low-saline rivers to give birth. In doing so, they endure physiological stress that would kill most marine fish. Young bull sharks eventually migrate to warmer offshore waters.

BULL SHARK

CYPRESS SWAMPS
Pond and bald cypresses thrive in swamps, forming dome-shaped clusters, with smaller, less stable trees at their edge. The largest trees in the middle are stabilized by buttress roots. Aerial roots play a role in respiration.

BALD AND POND

The only place in the world where alligators

FLORIDA PANTHER
North America's only subtropical wetland

PREDATOR IN PERIL
The Florida panther, a subspecies of puma, is the most endangered mammal in the Everglades—fewer than 100 remain. Its dwindling numbers have been boosted by other subspecies of puma introduced from Texas.